P 4 F C

Pre-Leaving Certificate Examination, 2025

English – Higher Level – Paper 1
(Option A)

Total Marks: 200

Time: 2 hours 50 minutes

- This paper is divided into two sections,
  Section I COMPREHENDING and Section II COMPOSING.
- The paper contains **three** texts on the general theme of **CONNECTING WITH NATURE.**
- Candidates should familiarise themselves with each of the texts before beginning their answers.
- Both sections of this paper (COMPREHENDING and COMPOSING) must be attempted.
- Each section carries 100 marks.

SECTION I – COMPREHENDING

- Two Questions, A and B, follow each text.
- Candidates must answer a Question A on one text and a Question B on a different text. Candidates must answer only one Question A and only one Question B.

N.B. Candidates may NOT answer a Question A and a Question B on the same text.

SECTION II – COMPOSING

- Candidates must write on **one** of the compositions 1 – 7.

SECTION I COMPREHENDING (100 marks)

TEXT 1 – A FATHER'S LESSONS IN NATURE

TEXT 1 is an edited extract from Richard Powers' novel, *The Overstory*, winner of the 2019 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction. The novel, set in America, tells the stories of a number of characters who are connected through their relationship with trees and their concern for saving the natural world. In this extract, we meet Patricia (Patty) Westerford, a young girl with a hearing impairment who will grow up to be an important botanist (plant scientist), and her father, Bill, an agricultural extension agent (adviser to farming communities).

It's 1950 and little Patty Westerford falls in love with her pet deer. Hers is made of twigs, though it's every bit alive. Also: squirrels from pairs of glued walnut shells, bears made of sweet-gum balls, dragons from the pods of Kentucky coffee trees, fairies donning acorn caps, and an angel whose pine-cone body needs only two holly leaves for wings.

She builds these creatures elaborate, miniature homes with pebbled front walks and mushroom furniture. She sleeps them in beds fitted with magnolia-petal comforters. She watches over them, the guiding spirit of a kingdom whose towns nestle behind closed doors in the burls of trees. Knotholes turn into windows, through which, squinting she can see the inviting parlours of woody citizens, the lost relatives of humans. She lives there with her creatures in the minuscule architecture of imagination, so much richer than the offerings of full-sized life. When her tiny wooden doll's head twists off, she plants it in the garden, certain it will grow another body.

All her twig creatures can talk, though most, like Patty, have no need of words. She herself said nothing until past the age of three. Her two older brothers interpreted her secret language for their frightened parents, who began to think she must be mentally deficient. They brought Patty into the clinic in Chillicothe for tests that revealed a deformation of the inner ear. The clinic fitted her with fist-sized hearing aids, which she hated. When her own speech started to flow at last, it hid her thoughts behind a slurry, hard for the uninitiated to comprehend. It didn't help that her face was thin and pointed. The neighbours' kids ran from her, this thing only borderline human. Acorn people are so much more forgiving.

Her father alone understands her woodlands world, as he always understands her every thickened word. She has a pride of place with him that the two boys accept. With them, Dad may throw softballs and tell bubble-gum wrapper jokes and play tag. But he reserves his best gifts for his little plant-girl, Patty.

Their closeness bothers her mother. "I ask you. Has there ever been such a little nation of two?"

Bill Westerford takes Patricia with him when he visits southwestern Ohio farms on his tours as an agricultural extension agent. Her presence gives his long journeys meaning. She rides copilot in the beaten-up pickup truck with the pine side panelling. The war is over, the world is on the mend, the country is drunk on science, key to better living, and Bill Westerford takes his daughter out to see the world.

Patty's mother objects to the long trips to farms. The girl should be in school. But her father's soft authority prevails. "She won't learn more anywhere than she will with me."

Mile after ploughed mile, they hold their roving tutorial. He faces her so she can read his moving lips. She laughs at his stories and stabs enthusiastic answers to each of his questions. Which is more numerous: the stars in the Milky Way or the chloroplasts on a single leaf of corn? Which trees flower before they leaf, and which flower after? Why are the leaves at the top of trees smaller than those at the bottom? If you carved your name four feet high in the bark of a beech tree, how high would it be after half a century?

She loves the answer to that last one: *Four feet*. Still four feet. Always four feet, however high the beech tree grows. She'll love that answer still, half a century later.

In this way, her love for acorns and their imagined lives turns bit by bit into an appreciation for botany. She becomes her father's star and only pupil for the simple reason that she alone, of all the family, sees what he knows: plants are wilful and crafty and after something, just like people. He tells her, on their drives, about all the unusual miracles that plants can devise. People have no monopoly on curious behaviour. Other creatures – bigger, slower, older, more durable – call the shots, make the weather, feed creation, and create the very air.

The drive from farm to farm, between last year's blights and next year's vanishing topsoil. He shows her extraordinary things: the spreading trunk of sycamore that swallowed up the cross-bar of an old bicycle someone left leaning against it decades ago. Two elms that draped their arms around each other and became one tree.

Her father is her water, air, earth, and sun. He teaches her how to see a tree, the living sheath of cells underneath every square inch of bark doing things no man has yet figured out.

This text has been adapted, for the purpose of assessment, without the author's prior consent.

N.B. Candidates may NOT answer Question A and Question B on the same text.

QUESTION A – 50 Marks

(i) Based on your reading of TEXT 1, explain three insights you gain into the relationship between Patty Westerford and her father, Bill. Support your answer with reference to the text. (15)

(ii) In TEXT 1, the writer describes the young Patty Westerford as imagining her twig creations are "every bit alive". Why do you think imagination is an important part of young people's lives? Develop three points in your response. (15)

(iii) Identify four elements of the writer's style, evident in TEXT 1, and discuss how they contribute to making this an intriguing and appealing piece of narrative writing. Support your answer with reference to the text. (20)

QUESTION B – 50 Marks

Your local Town Council is planning to cut down part of a forest in the area where you live in order to build a new road to improve traffic congestion. Write an **open letter**, to be published online, to the Council, protesting the plan, in which you: outline the importance of protecting forests, describe a future action you may take should the Council press ahead with its plans, and suggest an alternative to the planned new road as a measure to improve traffic congestion.

TEXT 2 – BIRDSONG – RECORDING IRELAND'S NATIVE BIRDS

TEXT 2 is an edited extract from an article from the TV and Radio Review section of *The Irish Times* by Una Mulally. In this article, she writes about Seán Ronayne, an ornithologist (scientist of birdlife) who is on a quest to record the song of every Irish bird species and about whom a documentary film has been made by the director Kathleen Harris. It was published in May 2024.

Seán Ronayne's nickname in school as a child was Nature Boy. His classmates had their heads shaved. He had a mop of curls. They wore Nike runners. He wore green Doc Martens. When given the opportunity, he would commandeer the nature table, bringing in leaves, flowers, skulls, eggshells, deer antlers. It was the space he loved most in the classroom, and nature – a class during which he would sometimes land himself in trouble for correcting the teacher – his favourite subject. Ronayne, a highly skilled ornithologist and wildlife sound recordist, is the subject of a remarkable new feature-length documentary, *Birdsong*, directed by Kathleen Harris, which comes out on RTÉ on May 26th.
Growing up in Cork, close to Cuskinny Marsh Nature Reserve in Cobh, Ronayne was a self-described "hyper" child. He couldn't sit still and found it hard to occupy himself indoors. His parents quickly learned that one way to diffuse his energy, stop him crying and running around, was to bring him out in nature. One of his earliest memories is as a child in a pram, seeing and hearing birds. His father could mimic the sounds, and Ronayne, in turn, would copy. A sense of calm would descend upon him. When he learned to speak, he asked his father about plants, fish, otters, badgers. He brought home everything from shells to animal droppings.

In 2022, the head of the video at *The Irish Times*, Chris Maddaloni, spotted a post on social media, where Ronayne said he was attempting to record the bird song of every species on the island of Ireland. At the time, the video department was working on a series about people with unusual jobs. Harris, then a video journalist with *The Irish Times*, was dispatched to meet Ronayne in Killarney National Park at dawn. Ronayne was slightly apprehensive about the encounter, having never really interacted with the media or assumed a public role. Indeed, public speaking used to be his greatest fear. But the journalist and the ornithologist got on well and so a filming project began to take shape.

In 2023, filming kicked in. This was when Ronayne was on the final stretch of his monumental project. By that stage, the birds he was trying to record were hard to find, many of them ground-nesting, such as corncrake on Tory Island, and skylark, "They're rare because of the fact that we've intensified our agricultural systems so greatly," Ronayne says, "We now cut silage fields up to four or five times a year, whereas in the past, they would have been cut by hand in September. Anything that was nesting in those meadows, taking shelter in the wildflowers, would have raised young no problem. Sometimes they would have even been double-brooded, they would have raised two batches of young. But now, they don't get a chance to raise a single batch. And if they do, if they are fooled into nesting in there, when the vegetation is high up in, say, late-April, they'll get cut up, which is what happens."

Ronayne's work, like the documentary, is bittersweet. There's his enthusiasm and love for wildlife, the epic journey of the recording project, but also the stark reality that the reason the project is complicated is down to horrific ecological degradation and habitat loss in Ireland. Still, the beauty of our natural landscape and the wildlife it's desperately holding on to signals a stunning call to action, protection and preservation.

When Harris began filming, Ronayne had around a dozen species left to record, "As time went by, they were rarer, scarcer, less vocal, harder to find, and sometimes a combination of all four." Take, for example, recording the golden eagle. "It's rare," Ronayne explains, "It's long-ranging, so a bird in Donegal could fly across to Scotland no problem to feed and then

come back. They're also really silent. The last year, there were lots of species like that."

Some of the most remarkable scenes in the film happen at the Skellig Islands, "one of the most important seabird colonies in Europe, if not the world", Ronayne says. When dusk falls, it's magic, as several species nesting there only become active at night. As he was listening to the strange songs of the Skellig birds, he thought about the 6th-century monks who once lived there. "This is a soundscape that has remained unchanged for all these centuries, despite everything that's gone on the mainland; modernisation, the building of so many roads and motorways, all of the machinery involved in our agricultural systems. This place is as is. The sound that I was hearing was the sound those monks would have heard from that very same location. That's a privilege."

It's a stint of filming that Harris will never forget either. "I've been to wild places," Harris says, "but I've never been somewhere that felt really given over to nature, to a species that isn't human. That island exists for the birds ... I don't think I've ever experienced anything like that."

When Ronayne was a guest on Tommy Tiernan's chat show earlier this year, his appearance and discussion of the documentary sparked a huge reaction. There is clearly a large appetite for what he has to say and how he says it. Ronayne describes it as "distressing" to encounter "an ingrained obsession with cutting down trees or trimming back hedges when it really doesn't need to be done ... It's often the case they don't realise the harm that they're doing to nature." Education, public pressure, advocacy and political action are key to addressing this, he says.

"I want people to be moved," Harris says of her film, "It would be amazing if it in any way gives people a door to look at something about our natural world a little differently than they did before." Harris says she feels there can be a "loneliness" in the worry that comes with the biodiversity and climate crises, but if people "can see a film and see people like Seán doing the work, I think that's motivating, and hopefully it inspires people to keep on that path".

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N.B. Candidates may NOT answer Question A and Question B on the same text.

QUESTION A – 50 Marks

(i) Based on your reading of TEXT 2, explain three insights you gain into the unique connection that Seán Ronayne has with the natural world. Support your answer with reference to the text. (15)

(ii) In TEXT 2, the writer describes Seán Ronayne's parents sometimes bringing him out into nature when he was a young child in order to calm him down. Why do you think the natural world has a calming effect on some people? Develop three points in your response. (15)

(iii) Identify four elements of the writer's style, evident in TEXT 2, and discuss how they contribute to making this an informative and engaging newspaper article. Support your answer with reference to the text. (20)

QUESTION B – 50 Marks

In TEXT 2, the writer states that public speaking used to be Seán Ronayne's "greatest fear". Write the text of a **short talk**, to be broadcast to an audience of young people online, on the importance of facing what you fear. In your talk you should: describe an occasion where you faced a fear/fears, outline how you overcame the fear/fears, and explain why others should face their fear/fears, as you did.

TEXT 3 – REWILDING – RETURNING LAND TO NATURE

TEXT 3 is an edited feature article from *The Guardian* by Rory Carroll, originally entitled "'People think you're an idiot': death metal Irish baron rewilds his estate". It was published in August 2021.

Randal Plunkett strides through the hip-high grass of Dunsany, a 650-hectare (1,600-acre) estate in the middle of Ireland, trailed by an invisible swarm of midges and his four jack russell terriers: Tiny, Lumpy, Chow and Beavis & Butt-Head.

The cattle and sheep are long gone, so too are the lawns and many of the crops. In their place is a riot of shrubs, flowers and trees, along with insects and creatures that call this fledgling wilderness their home. It is probably Ireland's most ambitious attempt at rewilding on private land, an attempt to recreate a vanished landscape in a swath of County Meath, 20 miles north-west of Dublin. According to the UN, the world needs to rewild and restore an area the size of China to meet commitments on nature and the climate – but not everyone applauds Ireland's pioneering effort. Public opinion has proven hostile, at times. "You'd be surprised when you live in a castle how many times people think you're just an idiot," says Plunkett, the 21st baron of Dunsany.

The 38-year-old, who was once a steak-eating bodybuilding death metal fan with no interest in land, is now vegan and on an environmental mission. He still loves death metal, and sports a ponytail and (fake) leather jacket, but he decided seven years ago to turn over 300 hectares of his estate to nature – no livestock, planting, sowing or weeding.

Some people considered it disgraceful neglect of an estate associated with agricultural innovation, he said. "They just thought I was a complete waster. Decadent, a fool. One farmer said I should be ashamed of myself for destroying the farm." Plunkett says vindication has come in multiple forms. Before, the estate had just three types of grass, now it has 23. "I didn't do it, the birds did." Trees regenerated and multiplied – oak, ash, beech, Scots pine and black poplar. "I see a lot of saplings growing that I haven't planted."

Lush, diverse vegetation attracted butterflies and other insects – "it's like a buffet for them" – which drew more birds, including rarely

seen woodpeckers, barn owls, red kites and sparrowhawks.

"I heard the call of a corncrake. I had to Google it to know what it was." There have also been sightings of snipe and stoats and an unconfirmed report of red squirrels. Botanists from Trinity College Dublin have started visiting to study the transformation. Last year Plunkett became the first Irish member of the European Rewilding Network, an advocacy group for wildernesses across Europe. In one striking success, wildcats have returned to Dutch forests after centuries of absence.

Ireland has a poor environmental record to contend with, despite its green image. In the 1980s it had more than 500 rivers and lakes with pristine water, now there are just 20, according to the Environmental Protection Agency. About 250,000 hectares of wetlands have been lost in the past two decades. Pollution from farming is widely blamed. The state has an ambitious tree-planting scheme but critics say too many of the new forests are sitka spruce, which carpet soil with acidic needles and smother wildlife.

"We're a fantastic country for remembering our history and culture but absolutely terrible at looking after our environment," says Plunkett. The Plunketts are one of Ireland's most storied families. Installed at Dunsany since 1402, their fortunes rose and fell over the centuries. Oliver Plunkett, a Catholic archbishop, was executed in England in 1681 on suspicion of a "popish plot"; he was canonised (made into a saint) in 1975. Horace Plunkett championed rural development and farming innovations in

the early 20th century. Other Plunketts were leading figures in politics and the arts.

Randal became the 21st baron after his father, Edward, died in 2011. Educated in the US, England and the Netherlands, he wanted to make films, not manage a farm and high-maintenance castle. "I've never been a country bumpkin. I saw it as a burden, a life of toil and servitude."

Uneasy about the climate crisis, at first Plunkett tried converting the estate to organic farming. When concern about the planet turned to alarm, he became vegan and decided to let a chunk of the estate revert to nature.

He also resolved to block poachers and horse-mounted hunters: "I decided to go to war." Plunkett patrolled the estate's forests and meadows, confronted interlopers, filmed them, summoned police and threatened legal action. "I've been threatened to my face and on social media with being beaten up, having my tyres slashed, you name it." He is bracing for the resumption of hunting season: "Come September, all hell breaks loose."

Plunkett, who recently had a baby daughter with his fiancée, allows small groups to visit the estate but does not want big crowds. "Paths, signs, a café? No." That would threaten the natural wilderness taking hold in the estate. He intends to continue making films intermittently – the next is a horror film – and to look after the estate in hope his daughter will eventually take over.

In keeping with family tradition, the vegan baron will not get rid of inherited furniture – not even the tiger-skin rug with head – but adds his own touches. "I might be the first generation here to bring in Ikea," he says.

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N.B. Candidates may NOT answer Question A and Question B on the same text.

QUESTION A – 50 Marks

(i) Based on your reading of TEXT 3, explain three insights you gain into the challenges faced by Randal Plunkett in rewilding his estate. Support your answer with reference to the text. (15)

(ii) In TEXT 3, the writer describes both personal and career changes made by Randal Plunkett. Why do you think that transformation stories appeal to many people? Develop three points in your response. (15)

(iii) Identify four elements of the writer's style, evident in TEXT 3, and discuss how they contribute to making this an informative and appealing feature article. Support your answer with reference to the text. (20)

QUESTION B – 50 Marks

In TEXT 3, Randal Plunkett states that "we're a fantastic country for remembering our history and culture". Write a **personal reflection** for your school's website on the importance of learning about other people's history and/or culture. In your personal reflection, you should: describe a moment when you learned about someone else's history and/or culture, outline how that learning impacted on your opinion(s), and explain why others should be open to different perspectives on history and/or culture.

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SECTION II COMPOSING (100 marks)

Write a composition on **any one** of the assignments that appear in **bold print** below.

Each composition carries 100 marks.

The composition assignments are intended to reflect language study in the areas of information, argument, persuasion, narration, and the aesthetic use of language.

1. In TEXT 1, Bill Westerford takes his daughter, Patty, with him on long trips to remote farms.

Write a short story, set on a remote farm, in which a hidden object plays an important role in the plot.

2. In TEXT 1, the writer states that "the war is over, the world is on the mend, the country is drunk on science, key to better living, and Bill Westerford takes his daughter out to see the world."

Write a personal essay in which you reflect on what you believe to be the "key to better living".

3. In TEXT 2, the writer states that Seán Ronayne was initially apprehensive about interacting with the media.

Write a discursive essay on the role that the media plays in shaping society today.

4. In TEXT 2, we learn how a childhood passion developed into Seán Ronayne's career.

Write the text of a speech, to be delivered to a group of young people, on the importance of curiosity in personal development.

5. In TEXT 3, Randal Plunkett states that he is bracing himself for the resumption of the hunting season in September.

Write a feature article, for publication in a popular magazine, on hunting in today's world. Your feature article may focus on positive and/or negative aspects of hunting.

6. In TEXT 3, Randal Plunkett, the owner of Dunsany Castle, is described as a "death metal Irish baron" who "rewilds his estate".

Write a short story, set in a castle, in which music plays an important role in the plot.

7. In TEXT 3, the writer states that Randal Plunkett "will not get rid of inherited furniture".

Write a personal essay about holding on to things from the past.